
Novelist accused of using AI to write book removed from French prize list

Thélyson Orélien had been in the running to win a top literary prize before the AI claim emerged on social media

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*The author Thélyson Orélien, whose book, *C'était ça ou mourir*, has sold about 35,000 copies. Photograph: Joel Saget/AFP/Getty Images*

The organisers of France's most prestigious literary prize said they had removed a critically acclaimed novel by a Canadian-Haitian writer from the longlist after an anonymous online account claimed the book was "almost entirely" written by AI.

The Académie Goncourt, a Paris-based literary organisation, said on Friday its decision to withdraw Thélyson Orélien's novel *C'était ça ou mourir* (It Was That or Die) was "driven by the desire to preserve the integrity of the Goncourt prize and the academy itself, whose central role is to promote and honour literature written by women and men".

The Haiti-born author's book is a lyrical first-person account of how a history and geography teacher flees a home country mired in gang violence and embarks on a perilous journey across 12 countries before finding a haven in Canada.

Published in France by Grasset in August, it has sold about 35,000 copies and won the Prix du roman Fnac, with translation rights sold to more than 20 countries.



The novel on display inside a bookstore in Paris. Photograph: Sarah Meyssonnier/Reuters

Allegations that the book was written using AI emerged on X on 21 September, the same day *It Was That or Die* won the Fnac prize for best novel.

An anonymous account called Balance ton Claude – a reference to Anthropic's AI agent – said it had fed the novel into the AI detection software Pangram and found it to be "almost entirely" written by artificial intelligence.

Questions have been raised over Pangram's accuracy, and French media outlets have found other AI detection programmes that identified *It Was That or Die* as very probably written by a human.

Orélien, 38, has denied the allegation, saying it was racially motivated. "I've always loved creating and writing," he said. "I don't see why I would use a machine."

He told the newspaper *Libération* that he used traditional language and rhythms that were Haitian and Caribbean. "The imagery, repetition and rhythm are a living language, they are mine."

The author of the anonymous X account was later identified on the pages of the centre-right newspaper *Le Figaro* as one of its own columnists, Samuel Fitoussi, the author of an essay against "wokeism" on film and TV.

On his own X account, Fitoussi said he had initiated his campaign because even though he was "techno-optimistic", he feared that "AI will cause the disappearance of reading and writing".

On Wednesday Philippe Claudel, the Académie Goncourt's president, had urged caution over the allegations. But separate accusations of plagiarism against Orélien published in French media appeared to have caused a change of heart.

Libération alleged in an article that the author plagiarised an award-winning short story from the preface of the French journalist Louis Pauwels' book *The Morning of the Magicians*, originally published in 1960.

In its statement the academy referred to the "plagiarisms of which its author has been guilty over time and which have just been revealed, as well as the convergent result of several analyses by trustworthy researchers and journalists highlighting the fact that [the book] is in all likelihood very largely the product of artificial intelligence".

"The aim is to send a clear message," it added, "to affirm that we neither endorse nor condone in any way the creation of texts generated with the help of AI."

In a statement shared with the *Guardian*, the novel's original publisher, Le Éditions du Boréal, said: "Unfortunately, at this stage, we are unable to confirm or deny the allegations the author is facing."

The Canada-based publisher said it was important not to jump to conclusions, adding: "Without credible, concrete evidence, it is not our place to decide whether this book has a right to exist."

Boréal said it was "concerned" about the newer plagiarism allegations, but added it was important to remember there was a real person behind the book. "We unequivocally condemn the hateful messages and personal attacks of recent days, and we urge everyone

to show restraint,” it said.

Orélien has said he will not comment further on the latest allegations. Speaking on Thursday at Les Correspondances literary festival in Manosque, southern France, he said: “There’s this desire not only to attack the book, but especially my voice ... to silence me,” adding that he would therefore “take a step back and wait until things have calmed down”.

The Académie Goncourt will publish its shortlist on 6 October and announce the winner of the prize on 4 November.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
in the running	短语	有望当选、参与角逐	had been in the running to win... 有望拿下……；源自赛马用语
longlist	n.	初选名单、长名单	removed from the longlist 被移出长名单；对照 shortlist 决选名单
withdraw	v.	收回、撤销	its decision to withdraw the novel 撤下小说；另义“取款、撤退”
integrity	n.	公正、廉正；（事物）完整性	preserve the integrity of the prize 维护奖项的公正；另义“完整无缺”
be driven by	短语	出于、源于	was “driven by the desire to...” 是出于……的考虑；被动式常用于说明动机
mired in	短语	深陷（困境）的	a home country mired in gang violence 深陷帮派暴力的祖国；mire 本义“泥沼”
haven	n.	避难所、安身之地	finding a haven in Canada 在加拿大找到安身之所
allegation	n.	（尚待证实的）指控、指称	Allegations... emerged on X 指控在 X 平台出现；动词 allege“据称”

词	词性	中文	备注
feed ... into	短语	把（数据）输入（系统）	fed the novel into AI detection software 把小说“喂”给 AI 检测软件
raise questions over	短语	对……提出质疑	Questions have been raised over Pangram's accuracy 对检测工具的准确性提出疑问
deny	v.	否认	has denied the allegation 否认指控；另义 deny sb sth“拒绝给予”
centre-right	adj.	中右翼的	the centre-right newspaper Le Figaro 中右翼报纸《费加罗报》
columnist	n.	专栏作家	one of its own columnists 该报自家专栏作者；column“专栏”
urge caution	短语	呼吁审慎、劝人先别下结论	had urged caution over the allegations 对指控呼吁慎重；urge sb to do sth
plagiarism	n.	剽窃、抄袭	accusations of plagiarism 抄袭指控；动词 plagiarise，行为入 plagiarist
endorse	v.	认可、赞同；（为商品）代言	neither endorse nor condone 既不认可也不容忍；第二义项常见于广告语境
condone	v.	姑息、容忍（错误行为）	同上句；比 tolerate 更强调“本应谴责却宽容”
in all likelihood	短语	十有八九、极有可能	is in all likelihood... largely the product of AI 极大概率是 AI 的产物
take a step back	短语	退一步、暂时抽身	take a step back and wait until things have calmed down 先退一步、等事态平息
shortlist	n.	决选名单、入围名单	publish its shortlist on 6 October 10月6日公布决选名单；流程：longlist → shortlist → winner

